

The protagonists of her paintings wear that familiar faraway look. They could be the 'Goat People', the dark man in a singlet, his arm tattooed, a parrot perched on his shoulder; his bosomy wife in a mauve blouse, her head covered with a blue-green dupatta; the son in a tee and shorts, and the two goats seemingly deep in slumber. The melancholic woman sitting on 'The Red Charpoi', her little son with blue skin and corkscrew curls sitting on the floor. 'The Goatherd-I', a little girl with mousy hair clutching her sleepy goat in her arms. 'The Boy Behind the Arras' half concealed. 'Madonna and Child II' sitting upright, as if posing before an early camera. 'Parvati and Ganesh', the elephant-headed child, a comical figure with his green skin and a globe for a belly. 'Yashoda and Krishna', wearing a peacock feather on his head. The dusky 'Namboodiri' with green eyes, an aquiline nose and a sandal paste mark on his forehead.

All these paintings and more, painted last year, are being displayed at Art Musings in Mumbai till February 29. They are part of an exhibition titled *Anjolie The Wanton Fabulist*, which brings Anjolie Ela Menon's work to Mumbai in a solo show after a gap of nine years. They bear the hallmark of the 83-year-old artist's work. The crow, parrot, chessboard print cloth, chair, colourful kite and, more significantly, the dreamy, withdrawn gaze of the varied characters in a full frontal hieratic attitude are all there. They appear regularly in Menon's work, painted invariably on Masonite.

"BEAUTY WILL ENDURE. IT IS NO LONGER A DIRTY WORD. BEAUTIFUL PAINTINGS ARE AGAIN BEING PAINTED BY ARTISTS," SAYS MENON

This distinctive style of figuration reflects Menon's admiration for Romanesque and Byzantine art which she discovered in her late teens hitchhiking through Italy and France. In contrast with the majesty and grandeur of early Christian





PRESS THE BUTTONS
Afrah Shafiq's Pac-Man style game (above); Pachpute's multi-pronged sculpture

EXHIBITION

EXPERIMENTS WITH ART

Kolkata's Experimenter Art Gallery showcases two artists working at the cutting edge of art

Multi/new media artist Afrah Shafiq's first solo show takes as its starting point the beautifully illustrated children's books distributed by the Soviet Union across India from the 1950s to the 1980s, and branches out in different directions. There is an old-fashioned video game that takes you down rabbit holes of narrative and facts around the writers and stories; there is an even more basic Pac-Man-level game where a young girl contemplates her coming marriage with sadness, the graphics taken from Russian folk vernacular; there is an exploration of the work of Daniil Kharms (from whom the